



▲ **Decorative peacock** statues in the restaurant of Maharajas' Express.

A touch of the old

The lifestyle of pre-Independence Princely States and their love for plush saloons deeply influenced the [Palace on Wheels](#). Western Railway assembled and the Ajmer Workshop rebuilt the 20 cars, including 12 vintage saloons and dining, lounge, and service cars. A precursor of all the luxury trains in India, it was fully booked on its inaugural run and earned around \$1 million – a princely sum in the 1980s. The modern broad-gauge train later replaced this metre-gauge version and continues to run today.

In the lap of luxury

There was no doubt that luxury train travel had immense potential in the Indian market, and it was only a matter of time that the Palace on Wheels would soon have competition.

In 1994–95, Gujarat Tourism and the Indian Railways launched the Royal Orient, which took its passengers on a tour of Gujarat and Rajasthan in palatial carriages named after Rajput kingdoms of old. The